

Psalms 107

Let Them Give Thanks Unto the Lord

O give thanks unto the Lord, for he is good: for his mercy endureth for ever

KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 O give thanks unto the LORD, for he is good: for his mercy endureth for ever.
- 2 Let the redeemed of the LORD say so, whom he hath redeemed from the hand of the enemy;
- 3 And gathered them out of the lands, from the east, and from the west, from the north, and from the south.
- 4 They wandered in the wilderness in a solitary way; they found no city to dwell in.
- 5 Hungry and thirsty, their soul fainted in them.
- 6 Then they cried unto the LORD in their trouble, and he delivered them out of their distresses.
- 7 And he led them forth by the right way, that they might go to a city of habitation.
- 8 Oh that men would praise the LORD for his goodness, and for his wonderful works to the children of men!
- 9 For he satisfieth the longing soul, and filleth the hungry soul with goodness.
- 10 Such as sit in darkness and in the shadow of death, being bound in affliction and iron;
- 11 Because they rebelled against the words of God, and contemned the counsel of the most High:
- 12 Therefore he brought down their heart with labour; they fell down, and there was none to help.
- 13 Then they cried unto the LORD in their trouble, and he saved them out of their distresses.
- 14 He brought them out of darkness and the shadow of death, and brake their bands in sunder.
- 15 Oh that men would praise the LORD for his goodness, and for his wonderful works to the children of men!
- 16 For he hath broken the gates of brass, and cut the bars of iron in sunder.
- 17 Fools because of their transgression, and because of their iniquities, are afflicted.
- 18 Their soul abhorreth all manner of meat; and they draw near unto the gates of death.
- 19 Then they cry unto the LORD in their trouble, and he saveth them out of their distresses.
- 20 He sent his word, and healed them, and delivered them from their destructions.
- 21 Oh that men would praise the LORD for his goodness, and for his wonderful works to the children of men!
- 22 And let them sacrifice the sacrifices of thanksgiving, and declare his works with rejoicing.
- 23 They that go down to the sea in ships, that do business in great waters;
- 24 These see the works of the LORD, and his wonders in the deep.
- 25 For he commandeth, and raiseth the stormy wind, which lifteth up the waves thereof.
- 26 They mount up to the heaven, they go down again to the depths: their soul is melted because of trouble.
- 27 They reel to and fro, and stagger like a drunken man, and are at their wit's end.
- 28 Then they cry unto the LORD in their trouble, and he bringeth them out of their distresses.
- 29 He maketh the storm a calm, so that the waves thereof are still.
- 30 Then are they glad because they be quiet; so he bringeth them unto their desired haven.
- 31 Oh that men would praise the LORD for his goodness, and for his wonderful works to the children of men!
- 32 Let them exalt him also in the congregation of the people, and praise him in the assembly of the elders.
- 33 He turneth rivers into a wilderness, and the watersprings into dry ground;
- 34 A fruitful land into barrenness, for the wickedness of them that dwell therein.
- 35 He turneth the wilderness into a standing water, and dry ground into watersprings.
- 36 And there he maketh the hungry to dwell, that they may prepare a city for habitation;
- 37 And sow the fields, and plant vineyards, which may yield fruits of increase.
- 38 He blesseth them also, so that they are multiplied greatly; and suffereth not their cattle to decrease.
- 39 Again, they are minished and brought low through oppression, affliction, and sorrow.
- 40 He poureth contempt upon princes, and causeth them to wander in the wilderness, where there is no way.
- 41 Yet setteth he the poor on high from affliction, and maketh him families like a flock.
- 42 The righteous shall see it, and rejoice: and all iniquity shall stop her mouth.

43 *Whoso is wise, and will observe these things, even they shall understand the lovingkindness of the LORD.*

2 • CONTEXT

Psalm 107 opens Book V of the Psalter with a structured celebration of God's rescue across four distinct scenarios—wanderers lost in the wilderness, prisoners in darkness and irons, the sick brought near death by their own folly, and sailors caught in a violent storm—each following the same pattern: distress, cry to the Lord, deliverance, and a call to give thanks. Henry treats the repeated refrain as deliberately instructive, training the reader to recognize the same divine rescue pattern across radically different kinds of trouble.

3 • VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-3

The call to thanksgiving opens broadly: give thanks, for He is good, His mercy endures forever. The redeemed are pictured as gathered from every direction—east, west, north, and south—a single community formed out of scattered rescue.

Verse 4-9

The first scenario: wanderers in the wilderness, finding no city to dwell in, hungry and thirsty, their soul fainting within them. They cried to the Lord in their trouble, and He delivered them from their distresses, leading them by a right way to a city of habitation. The refrain follows: let them praise the Lord for His goodness, for He satisfies the longing soul and fills the hungry with goodness.

Verse 10-16

The second scenario: those sitting in darkness and the shadow of death, bound in affliction and iron because they rebelled against God's words and despised His counsel. Their hearts brought down through hard labor, they fell down with no one to help—until they cried to the Lord and were saved, brought out of darkness, their bands broken. The refrain repeats, now specific to their rescue: He has broken gates of brass and cut bars of iron in two.

Verse 17-22

The third scenario: fools afflicted because of their own transgression and iniquity, their soul abhorring all food, drawing near the gates of death. Again they cried to the Lord, and He saved them, sending His word and healing them, delivering them from destruction. The refrain calls them specifically to sacrifice thanksgiving and declare His works with rejoicing—healing tied to grateful testimony, not silent relief.

Verse 23-32

The fourth and most vivid scenario: those who go down to the sea in ships, witnessing God's works in the deep—He commands, and a stormy wind lifts up the waves, sailors mounting up to heaven and down to the depths, their soul melting because of trouble, reeling like drunken men, at their wits' end. They cried to the Lord, and He stilled the storm, calming the waves, bringing them to their desired haven glad because of the quiet. The refrain here expands to public testimony: let them exalt Him in the assembly of the people and praise Him in the company of the elders.

Verse 33-38

The psalm turns from individual rescue to broader providence: God turns rivers into wilderness and fruitful land into barrenness because of the wickedness of those who dwell there, yet also turns wilderness into pools of water, settling the hungry there to build a city, sow fields, plant vineyards, and be blessed with great increase—judgment and provision both shown as expressions of the same sovereign hand.

Verse 39-43

A final movement traces decline and restoration in national life: brought low through oppression, affliction, and sorrow, yet God pours contempt on princes and causes them to wander, while setting the poor on high from affliction and making families increase like a flock. The righteous see this and rejoice, while iniquity is silenced; the psalm closes by naming its whole purpose: whoever is wise will observe these things and understand the Lord's lovingkindness.

4 • MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

God's rescuing mercy is not limited to one kind of crisis; the same pattern of cry, deliverance, and required thanksgiving repeats across wilderness wandering, imprisonment, self-inflicted sickness, and mortal danger at sea, showing His care to be as varied as human trouble itself. The psalm's explicit purpose is that observing this pattern should produce wisdom—recognizing God's lovingkindness at work across every category of need, not only the ones that feel dignified or blameless.

Application for life today.

Identify which of the four scenarios—wandering without direction, bound by consequences, suffering from your own folly, or overwhelmed by circumstances beyond your control—most describes your current situation, and let this psalm's specific refrain

shape a specific prayer of thanksgiving in response. Notice that the third scenario (vv. 17–22) explicitly includes self-inflicted trouble—if your own choices contributed to a hardship, this psalm does not exclude you from crying out and being heard. Practice the psalm's insistence on public, not merely private, thanksgiving (vv. 22, 32)—declare specific rescues to others, not only to God.

5 • REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. Which of the four rescue scenarios—wandering, imprisonment, self-inflicted suffering, or overwhelming circumstance—most matches where you are right now, and what does its specific refrain invite you to pray?

2. How does the third scenario's inclusion of self-inflicted trouble (vv. 17–18) challenge any hesitation you feel about bringing a hardship you caused yourself to God?

3. What specific rescue in your life needs to move from private relief into public testimony, as verses 22 and 32 call for, rather than staying unspoken?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).